LORD OF THE STORM

In Fatehpur Sikri it was the beginning of the monsoon season when an urgent summons arrived from Munim Khan in Bihar, requesting assistance in quelling the rising ambition of Daud Khan Afghan. Akbar decided that together with ‘the princes and a few of the ladies and the cream of the courtiers’, a river expedition down the Yamuna for the royal retinue would be organized while the army marched alongside on land. By 15 June 1574, a large fleet of boats was readied for the royal party. The two largest boats had enormous carved prows, one in the shape of a lion, and one in the shape of a crocodile. Even ‘gardens, such as clever craftsmen could not make on land’ were constructed on some of the boats for the pleasure of the harem while the ‘bows of every one of those water-houses were made in the shape of animals so as to astonish spectators’. Two bull elephants, Bal Sundar and Saman, were also to be a part of the river fleet, each in his own boat along with two female elephants. Bal Sundar was a particularly beloved imperial elephant, for he had ‘the strength to pull down mountains and break the ranks of armies, but always retained perfect control of himself and obedience to his driver, never losing his judgment even in the height of mast’. These were supremely valued qualities, ones believed to be embodied in Akbar himself.

Akbar had given a huge boost to his navy’s operations which in earlier times had consisted of a motley assembly of hastily requisitioned crafts, discarded after every season. Now the navy had been rationalized and expanded, and accepted any ‘experienced seamen acquainted with the tides, the depths of the ocean, the time when the several winds blow’ and the imperial sailor was urged to be ‘hale and strong, a good swimmer, kind hearted, hard-working, capable of bearing fatigue and patient’. The ports of Gujarat and, soon, Bengal, would give the Mughals access to centres of ship-building with their proximity to forests rich in teak and sundari, native woods which would prove much more durable than European oak and pine. Most Mughal warships, because they were primarily used in river and coastal operations, were smaller and not as heavily armed as the European